

chapter fifteen

Cross-Cultural Communication



CULTURE

Dutch sociologist Geert Hofstede defined culture as,

“the collective programming of the mind which distinguishes the members of one category of people from another”

- Cultures is the shared ways in which groups of people understand and interpret the world.
- National culture is that component of our mental programming which we share with more of our compatriots as opposed to most other world citizens (Geert Hofstede).

THE GROWING IMPORTANCE OF CROSS-CULTURAL COMMUNICATION

- A primary reason is that businesses sell their products and services both domestically and internationally. Being able to communicate with others will help you be more successful in **understanding customers' needs**, communicating how your company can meet these needs, and winning their business.
- In addition to being a more effective employee, you will be more efficient both within and outside your company. You will be able to **work harmoniously** with those from other cultures, creating a more comfortable and productive workplace.
- If cultural barriers are minimized, you will be able to **hire a wider variety of good people**. Also, you will avoid problems stemming solely from misinterpretations.
- A final reason is that your attention to communicating clearly with those from other cultures will **enrich your business and personal life**.

Adapting your words, sentences, and overall message to your audience is always important, and never more so than in cross cultural situations. Clarity, courtesy, and correctness are appreciated everywhere.

DIMENSIONS OF CULTURAL DIFFERENCE

- The title of a popular book on international business claims that “the world is flat,” and many would agree that we seem to have more and more in common globally. But cultural differences are still strong in many places and situations.
- Even within one culture there can be many subcultures. With only a moment’s reflection on regional, ethnic, and even gender differences within any culture, you will realize that this is true.
- The person with whom you are communicating may be completely unrepresentative of his or her culture of origin.
- Knowing something about these three topics—**topography**, **history**, and **religion**—can tell you a great deal about the outlook of a country’s or region’s natives.
- Sensitivity to these dimensions will help you avoid **ethnocentrism**—the tendency to see only your own cultural programming as “normal”.

1. Topography

- Topography is the study of the shape and features of land surfaces. The topography of an area could refer to the surface shapes and features themselves, or a description.
- Landforms might include physical features like mountains or oceans. If you live in the mountains, you're likely to develop a particular culture that adapts to life at a high altitude.

For example,

- You might wear heavier clothing and tend to be physically stronger as a result of climbing often. On the other hand, living near an ocean might mean you wear lighter clothing and incorporate swimming and fishing into your culture to a great extent.
- Japan's island geography with limited resources has fostered a culture that values efficiency and conservation, reflected in their just-in-time manufacturing systems that minimize waste.

2. History

Historical experiences shape business values and negotiation approaches. Germany's post-WWII economic rebuilding created a business culture with strong emphasis on precision and quality assurance, making "German engineering" a global mark of excellence. Meanwhile, India's colonial history has influenced its legal systems and English-language advantage in the global IT and business process outsourcing industries.

3. Religion

Religious traditions deeply influence business ethics and practices. In Islamic banking, Sharia-compliant financial products prohibit charging interest, affecting how multinational banks must structure offerings in Muslim-majority markets. In predominantly Buddhist Thailand, relationship-building often takes precedence over immediate deal-making, requiring patience from Western business partners. 6

Cultural Differences When Communicating

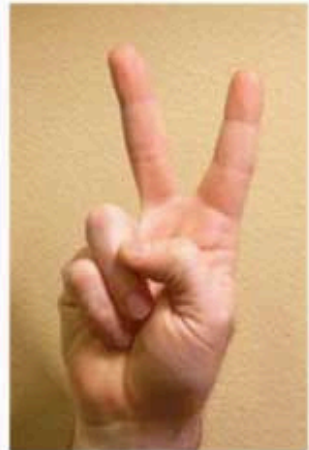
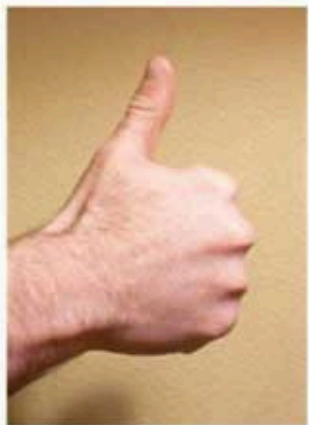
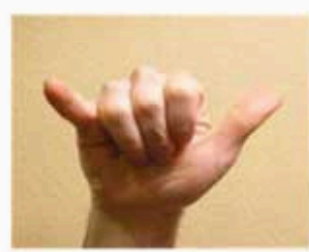
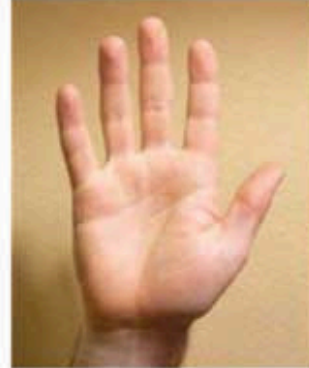


Body Position and Movements

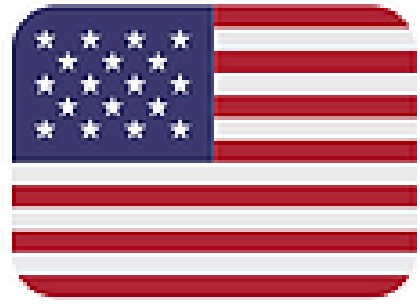
- These positions and movements differ by culture, and the differences can affect communication. Communication with body parts (hands, arms, head, etc.) varies by culture.
- And when people from those countries encounter U.S. natives who do not bow on meeting and leaving each other, they are likely to interpret the omission as rude. Similarly, people from the United States see standing up as the appropriate thing to do on certain occasions (as when someone enters the room), whereas people from some other cultures do not.
- In Japan, people greet each other by bowing. A bow can range from a small nod of the head to a deep bend at the waist. A deeper, longer bow indicates respect and conversely a small nod with the head is casual and informal. Bowing is also used to thank, apologize, make a request or ask someone a favor.



- Communication with body parts (hands, arms, head, etc.) varies by culture.
- As you know, movements of certain body parts (especially the hands) are a vital form of human communication. Some of these movements have no definite meaning even within a culture. But some have clear meanings, and these meanings may differ by culture. In the United States an up-and-down movement of the head means yes and a side-to-side movement of the head means no.
- Hand gestures can have many different meanings. The two-fingered sign that means “victory” or “peace” in the United States is considered vulgar in Australia, and the “OK” sign is insulting in such diverse countries as Russia, Germany, and Brazil

	<i>“V” for victory.</i> Use this gesture with caution! While in North America it signs victory or peace, in England and Australia it means something closer to “take this!”
	<i>The “OK” gesture.</i> While in North America it means things are going well, in France it means a person is thought to be worthless, in Japan it refers to money, and in Brazil, Russia, and Germany it means something really not appropriate for the workplace.
	The <i>“thumbs up”</i> means one in Germany, five in Japan, but good job in North America. This can lead to confusion.
	<i>“Hook ‘em horns.”</i> In Texas this is the University of Texas rallying call because it looks like the horns of a bull. However, in Italy it means you are being tricked, while in Brazil and Venezuela it means you are warding off evil.
	<i>Waving your hand.</i> In much of Europe waving your hand indicates a disagreement. However, in North America it is routinely used as a way to signal greetings or to get someone’s attention.

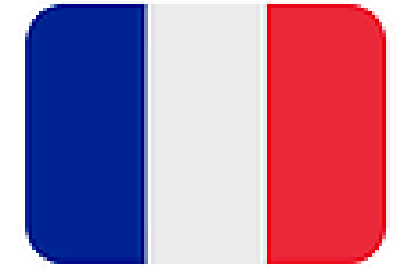
For example, let's take a look at this "okay" gesture in which one make a circle with his index finger and thumb while the other fingers raised slightly:



North Americans use this to indicate OK or approval

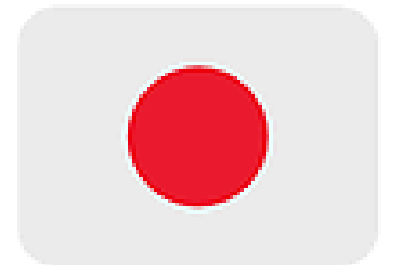


You're regarded as vulgar if you make this sign in Brazil



For the French, the gesture stands for zero or nothing

When the Japanese make this sign, they are signaling money



COMMUNICATION MATTERS

Carefully Present and Receive a Business Card in Japan

In Japan, it is considered bad manners to go to a business meeting without a business card, or *meishi*. There are a number of ways to present the card, but receiving it is an art, too. If you want to make a good impression on the presenter, receive it in both hands, especially when the other party is senior in age or status or a potential customer.

Be careful not to fiddle with the card or put it in your rear pocket—that is considered crude. Put it in some distinctive case. Those who do business in both countries often have their business cards translated on the back, as the examples here show.

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Handshaking Culture of Different Countries

Culture	Handshakes
Americans	Firm, five to seven pumps
Germans	Brusque, firm, single pump, repeated upon arrival and departure
French	Light, quick, not offered to superiors, repeated upon arrival and departure, may include a double kiss
British	Soft, three to five pumps
Hispanics	Moderate grasp, repeated frequently
Latin Americans	Firm, long-lasting
Middle Easterners	Gentle, repeated frequently
Asians	Gentle; for some, shaking hands is unfamiliar and uncomfortable (an exception to this is the Korean, who generally has a firm handshake)
Arabs	Gentle, longlasting, sometimes with kisses on both cheeks

Views and Practices Concerning Factors of Human Relationships

Differing attitudes toward various factors of human relationships cause communication problems

- Time (monochronic vs. Polychronic Time)
- Space (U.S.-2 feet, Arab Culture).
- Odors (USA vs. Asian)
- Frankness (Low context culture vs. High Context Culture).
- Social Hierarchy (Power Distance and Masculinity and Femininity).
- Workplace Values (USA, Asia: Japan and Spain).
- Expression of emotions (middle east).

Time

- Monochronic time
- Polychronic time



Time (monochronic vs. Polychronic Time)

Views about time differ widely

In the United States, people tend to be monochronic. They regard time as something that must be planned for the most efficient use. They strive to meet deadlines, to be punctual, to conduct business quickly, and to work on a schedule.

In some other cultures (especially those of the Middle East and some parts of Asia), people are polychronic, viewing time in a more relaxed way. In fact, some of them hold the view that important people should be late to show that they are busy. In business negotiations, the people in these cultures move at a deliberately slow pace, engaging in casual talk before getting to the main issue

Monochronic People

- do one thing at a time
- concentrate on the job
- are committed to the job
- are accustomed to short-term relationships

Polychronic People

- do many things at once
- are highly distractible
- are committed to people
- tend to build lifetime relationships

Space

Space is viewed differently by different cultures. In some cultures, people want to be far apart; in other cultures, they want to be close.

In some cultures like Arab culture people stand closer to each other; not following this practice is considered impolite and bad etiquette. Americans view personal space as a right and tend to respect this right of others at least 2 feet.

Odors

Some cultures view body odors as bad; others view them as normal. Americans work hard to neutralize body odors or cover them up and view those with body odors as dirty and unsanitary. On the other hand, in some Asian cultures people view body odors not as something to be hidden but as something that friends should experience.

Frankness

- North Americans tend to be relatively frank or explicit in their relationships with others, quickly getting to the point and perhaps being blunt and sharp in doing so. Germans and Israelis are even more frank than Americans. Asians tend to be far more reticent or implicit and sometimes go to great lengths to save face or not to offend.
- Phone customs may be an exception, especially among the Chinese, who tend to end telephone calls abruptly after their purpose has been accomplished. North Americans, on the other hand, tend to move on to friendly talk and clearly prepare the listener for the end of the call.

Workplace Values

- Views about the relationships of employers and employees also may differ by culture.
- North American workers expect to change companies in their career a number of times; and they expect companies to fire them from time to time. Employees expect to move freely from job to job, and they expect employers to hire and fire as their needs change.
- Expectations are quite different in some other cultures. In Japan, for example, employment tends to be for a lifetime. The company is viewed much like a family, with loyalty expected from employees and employer. Such differences have caused misunderstandings in American–Japanese joint ventures.

Expression of Emotions

- Some cultures combine business and social pleasure; others do not. Some expect to engage in aggressive bargaining in business transactions; others prefer straightforward dealings.
- Some talk loudly and with emotion; others communicate orally in a subdued manner.
- Some communicate with emphasis on economy of expression; others communicate with an abundance of verbiage.
- Asian cultures strongly frown upon public displays of affection Westerners, on the other hand, accept at least a moderate display of affection.

Many more such differences exist.

Low Context Culture vs. High Context Culture by Anthropologist Edward T. Hall

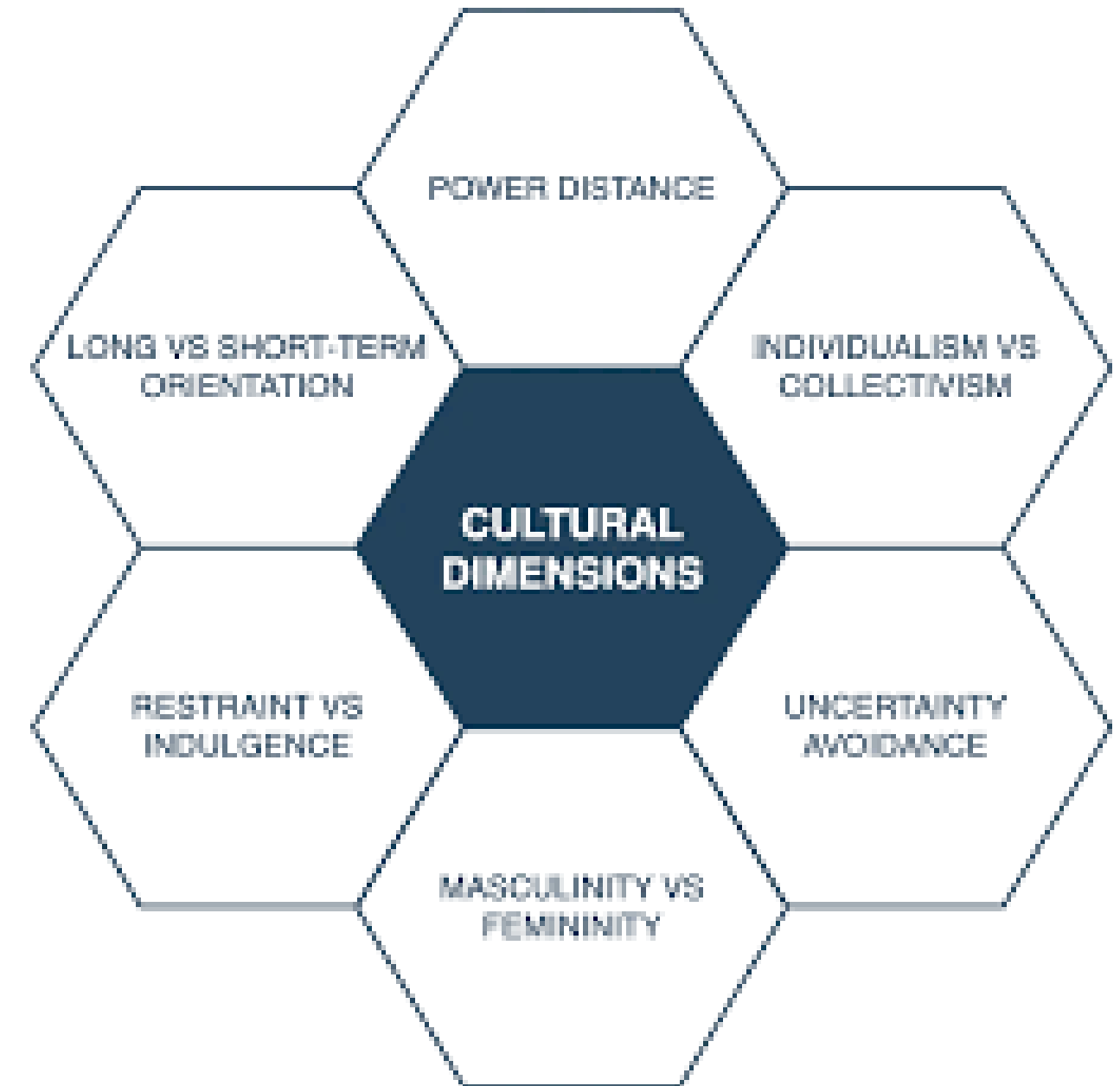
Low-context communicators, in Hall's model, tend to express themselves in concrete, direct, and explicit ways. The gist of the message and everything one needs in order to interpret it are all there in the message. American, German, Scandinavian, Swiss, and Finnish people tend to fall into this category. They use and value a straightforward communication style.

High-context communicators use a more multimodal style. Rather than putting everything they mean into words, they use eye movements, body language, tone of voice, and other nonverbal elements to give interpretational cues. Though they communicate implicitly, they expect you to be able to interpret their points by drawing on your knowledge of their cultural context. French, Japanese, Indian, Irish, British, and Arabic people tend to be high-context communicators—though of course their contexts can differ dramatically.

Lately Hall's model has come under fire for being unsupported by formal research. In an extensive review of the topic, Peter Cardon has shown that Hall's generalizations arose from unsystematic observation and have often been contradicted. On the other hand, Cardon's study also shows that **Hall's theory of contexting is the most cited theory in cross-cultural communication.** The fact that so many researchers, teachers, and consultants have found it useful suggests that, despite its flaws, the model has a certain tried-and-true appeal. So put it into your cross-cultural communication tool box—and apply with caution.

Geert Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions

- Developed by Dutch sociologist Geert Hofstede through research at IBM.
- Dimensions describe national cultures on measurable scales.
- Useful for understanding work styles, leadership, negotiation, and communication preferences.



1. Power Distance Index (PDI) Power Distance refers to the extent to which less powerful members of organizations and societies accept and expect that power is distributed unequally.

- **High PDI countries** (e.g., Malaysia, Mexico): Emphasize hierarchy, authority, and centralized decision-making. Subordinates are unlikely to question their superiors.
- **Low PDI countries** (e.g., Denmark, New Zealand): Promote equality and participative decision-making. Employees are encouraged to express their opinions.

Business Implication: In high PDI cultures, managers should maintain formality and respect hierarchy. In low PDI cultures, leaders can adopt a more democratic and inclusive style.

2. Individualism vs. Collectivism (IDV) This dimension measures the degree of interdependence a society maintains among its members.

- **Individualistic cultures** (e.g., USA, UK): Value personal achievements, individual rights, and autonomy. Communication tends to be direct.
- **Collectivist cultures** (e.g., China, Indonesia): Value group loyalty, harmony, and consensus. Communication tends to be indirect and context-sensitive.

Business Implication: Individualist settings favor personal accountability and direct feedback, while collectivist cultures prioritize teamwork and group harmony.

3. Masculinity vs. Femininity (MAS) This dimension explores the distribution of emotional roles between genders and the value placed on competitiveness versus care.

- **Masculine cultures** (e.g., Japan, Germany): Emphasize competition, achievement, and success.
- **Feminine cultures** (e.g., Sweden, Netherlands): Emphasize quality of life, nurturing, and cooperation.

Business Implication: In masculine cultures, emphasize performance and outcomes. In feminine cultures, emphasize work-life balance and team collaboration.

4. Uncertainty Avoidance Index (UAI) Uncertainty Avoidance indicates how cultures deal with the unknown and ambiguity.

- **High UAI countries** (e.g., Greece, Portugal): Prefer structured situations, rules, and stability.
- **Low UAI countries** (e.g., Singapore, India): More accepting of change, innovation, and flexible rules.

Business Implication: High UAI cultures require detailed planning and risk minimization. Low UAI cultures are more open to experimentation and informal practices.

5. Long-Term vs. Short-Term Orientation (LTO) This dimension reflects the extent to which a society maintains links with its own past while dealing with the challenges of the present and future.

- **Long-term oriented cultures** (e.g., China, South Korea): Value perseverance, thrift, and future rewards.
- **Short-term oriented cultures** (e.g., USA, Nigeria): Value traditions, social obligations, and immediate outcomes.

Business Implication: Long-term cultures focus on relationship-building and sustainability, while short-term cultures prioritize quick results and respect for tradition.

6. Indulgence vs. Restraint (IVR) This dimension measures the degree of freedom that societal norms give to citizens in fulfilling their human desires.

- **Indulgent cultures** (e.g., Australia, Brazil): Encourage gratification of desires and having fun.
- **Restrained cultures** (e.g., Russia, Pakistan): Regulate gratification through strict social norms.

Business Implication: In indulgent cultures, work environments may be more relaxed and open. In restrained cultures, discipline and adherence to norms are expected.

Richard D. Lewis: Cultural Types Model

Lewis categorized cultures into three broad communication and behavior types: **Linear-Active, Multi-Active, and Reactive.** These styles describe how people from different cultures plan, communicate, and relate in business and social interactions.

1. Linear Actives

Characteristics

- Task-oriented
- Highly organized and punctual
- Plan in advance, follow schedules strictly
- Prefer facts, logic, and written communication
- Speak one person at a time

Business Behavior

- Emphasize agendas, deadlines, and contracts
- Expect punctuality and rational decision-making
- Prefer dealing with one thing at a time

Countries: Germany, Switzerland, USA, UK, Netherlands, Scandinavia

Example: A German manager sticks closely to an agenda and expects a formal presentation backed by data.

2. Multi-Actives

Characteristics

- People-oriented
- Flexible and spontaneous
- Often talkative and emotional
- Do many things at once
- Prefer face-to-face communication

Business Behavior

- Prefer relationship-building before conducting business
- May interrupt or talk over each other
- Comfortable with flexible deadlines and changing priorities

Countries: Italy, Spain, Latin America, Arab nations, sub-Saharan Africa

Example: A Brazilian negotiator might discuss personal matters first and shift topics frequently during a meeting.

3. Reactives

Characteristics

- Respectful, good listeners
- Value harmony and non-confrontation
- Often reserved and indirect in communication
- Take time before responding

Business Behavior

- Avoid open disagreement
- Value silence and reflection
- Prefer building trust and consensus before decisions

Countries: China, Japan, Korea, Vietnam, Finland

Example: A Japanese executive may take time to respond after a proposal and avoid saying “no” directly.

Summary Table

Type	Key Traits	Sample Countries
Linear-Active	Logical, task-focused, scheduled	Germany, UK, USA
Multi-Active	People-focused, flexible, emotional	Italy, Brazil, Mexico
Reactive	Listening-focused, calm, respectful	Japan, China, Korea

Effects on Business Communication

- Cultural differences affect communication.
- Our communication techniques are not universally acceptable.
People in Asian cultures, for example, generally favor a somewhat indirect approach for messages. They begin with an identification of context—that is, a description of the situation the message concerns.
- You must modify your communications to fit the culture of your recipient.

What to do about this problem? You have no choice but to become a student of culture. You must learn the cultures of those with whom you communicate. Don't expect them to understand your culture, although many of them do. With your recipient's culture in mind, you then modify your communication accordingly

Lack of Language Equivalency

- The people on earth use more than 3,000 languages
The same word used in 2 language with different meanings: florists.
Unfortunately, wide differences among languages make precisely equivalent translations difficult.
- we think of a florist as someone who sells flowers and related items in a store. In some cultures, however, flowers are sold by street vendors, mainly women and children. Obviously, our florist does not have a precise equivalent in the language of such cultures.
- A word in one language may not have a corresponding words in another language.
- The French have no word to distinguish between mind and brain, and man and gentleman Spanish: Chairman-president.
- The Spanish have no word to distinguish between a chairman and a president

Lack of Language Equivalency (continued)

- Another explanation for the lack of language equivalency is the grammatical and syntactic differences among languages. Some languages (Urdu, for example) have no gerunds
- Adding to these equivalency problems is the problem of multiple word meanings. Like English, other languages have more than one meaning for many words. Think, for example, of our numerous meanings for the simple word run(to move fast, to compete for office and many more)
- The Oxford English Dictionary uses over 15,000 words to define what. Unless one knows a language well, it is difficult to know which of the meanings is intended.

Lack of Language Equivalency (continued)

- Certain Manners of expression of a culture:

For example, we might say, “Business couldn’t be better,” meaning business is very good. One from another culture might understand the sentence to mean “Business is bad” (impossible to improve). Or we might say, “We could never be too nice to our customers,” meaning try as we may, we couldn’t be overly nice. To one from another culture, the sentence

- One example is the simple word yes, a word that has an equivalent in all languages. “The Chinese yes, like the Japanese yes, can often be understood by Americans and British as their English yes. But the Chinese yes often means ‘I am listening.’ Or it may be understood in English as the opposite. For example, when an American says to a Chinese counterpart, ‘I see you don’t agree with this clause,’ the Chinese will usually reply, ‘Yes’ meaning a polite agreement with the negative question: ‘Yes, you are right. I do not agree with the clause.’
- Overcoming those problems: Know the language, ask, be aware of the problem, back translating.

Difficulties with English

2 Word Verbs:(breakthrough, Cover-up, drive-in, show-off, clean-up)

Two Word Verbs	Suggested Substitutes
Give Up	Surrender
Speed Up, Hurry Up	Accelerate
Go on, Keep on	Continue
Put off	Defer, delay
Take off	Depart, remove
Come Down	Descend
Go in , Come in, Get in	Enter

Difficulties with English

- Slang and colloquialisms cause problems.
- We use such words in everyday communication. But avoid them in cross-cultural correspondence.

Not This	But This
That's just off the top of my head.	Here's a quick idea
They couldn't make heads or tails of the report.	They couldn't understand the report.
The sales campaign was a flop.	The sales campaign was a failure.
Don't let him get your goat	Don't let him upset you.

Advice for Communicating Across Cultures

- Do your research.
- Know yourself and your company.
- Be aware of the stereotype.
- Adapt English to your audience (talk simply, clearly and slowly, avoid double barreled and negative questions, ask open ended questions)
- Be open to Change.

Thank You